

Understanding disorders of gut–brain interaction

What a DGBI is, why symptoms are real, and how the gut and brain work together.

A **disorder of gut–brain interaction** (DGBI) is a condition where the gut and the brain aren't communicating smoothly. The digestive system works, but the constant two-way signalling between gut and brain becomes over-sensitive or dysregulated — producing real, often distressing symptoms.

Real, not imagined

A DGBI is not “all in your head”, and normal test results do not mean nothing is wrong. The pain, nausea, urgency or discomfort are genuine — they arise from how the gut–brain system is functioning, not from imagination.

Common examples

- ☐ Irritable bowel syndrome (IBS)
- ☐ Functional dyspepsia (upper-gut discomfort, early fullness)
- ☐ Chronic nausea and vomiting syndromes
- ☐ Functional constipation and motility disorders

The gut–brain axis

The gut and brain are in constant conversation through nerves, hormones and the gut's own microbiome. This is why stress can upset digestion, and why gut symptoms can affect mood and concentration. When the system is on high alert, ordinary gut sensations can be amplified and read as threatening.

What helps

The strongest results come from combining good medical care with support for the nervous system and the mind. Psychological approaches don't replace medical treatment — they calm the amplifying loops, rebuild confidence, and help you live well alongside symptoms.

The EF Health approach — Centre · Clarify · Choose

Centre settles the nervous system so the body can steady. **Clarify** helps you understand the signal and separate symptom from story. **Choose** supports values-based action at a sustainable pace — so function is restored, not just waited for.

This sheet is general information — not a diagnosis or a substitute for medical care. EF Health psychological support works alongside your medical team, never instead of it. If your symptoms are new, severe, or changing, please speak with your GP or specialist.

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